

Who will rule the Web?



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Web authoring has evolved from designing simple pages to integrating complex technologies. We test two products that boast of being a developer's best companion

Over the past two years, Macromedia has dominated the Web site authoring market with Dreamweaver being the default application of choice for most Web site designers. Even though there are scores of Web authoring tools for enthusiasts and professionals alike, none of them really measure up against Macromedia's baby. With a plethora of features, support for the latest Web standards, a large user base and solid integration of support tools, Dreamweaver has been the undisputed king of the Web, and with its latest version, Dreamweaver MX, it intends to stay on top.

Adobe GoLive has consistently improved with each version and has matured from a program with strong promise to a potential front-runner. Now, with the introduction of GoLive 6.0, Adobe hopes to finally make a significant dent in Macromedia's dominance.

We put Macromedia Dreamweaver MX and Adobe GoLive 6.0 under the microscope to verify their claims to the top spot. We evaluated these software based on the features offered, their user interface, ease of use, technologies supported, HTML editing capabilities and integration with other tools and technologies. All tests were carried out on a system with a Pentium III 1.2 GHz Tualatin processor, 256 MB

RAM and a 20 GB hard disk, running Windows 98 SE.

User interface

The interface of any development or design tool needs to be as intuitive as possible while being functional at the same time. The interface should grow on you and finding tools should come naturally. Initially most software seem pretty useable, but over a period of time those unnecessary clicks start taking a toll on your productivity and become irritatingly glaring. The interface should allow for a great deal of customisability that lets you create and place the tools you need most in and around your work area. This

allows for clean and uncluttered working environments that let you unleash the full power of your creativity.

The interface of Dreamweaver MX is simply wonderful. The addition of fully dockable panels and tabbed documents adds a new dimension of customisability. Many parts of the Dreamweaver MX interface can be adjusted and reorganised, and you can even rename items. The collapsible panels can be grouped the way you want and the toolbar too is highly customisable.

Adobe GoLive finds itself dwarfed against the number of options that Dreamweaver MX offers and only allows a certain degree of customisability. To be fair to GoLive, you do have the option of docking individual palettes as single menu items. What is surprisingly missing from GoLive is the typical Adobe interface system. The commonality of the interface amongst Adobe products is very useful and makes working easy when you shift from one program to the other but the GoLive interface is radically different, though it is similar to the earlier GoLive interfaces. The only common feature that we found was the custom workspace profiler that allows you to save different interface layouts for specific users.



Dreamweaver MX has arguably the best interface we've seen in a Web authoring tool